subjective imaginations on what is given. The representation of silver refers to real silver.

Explanation of cognitive error without admitting that ideas may lack reference to real objects is also a feature of ***Prabhakara***'s theory of error.

Further reading: Hiriyanna 1993; Matilal 1986

Apoha-vada ('exclusion of the other': Buddhist theory of meaning): realists think that objective general features (universal properties, natural kinds, quality-types such as blues, red, shapes and sizes, and action types) serve as the basis for the repeated applications of general terms or predicates. On this view we classify some individual animals as cows because they form a natural kind. The property 'being a cow' is itself an entity common to all cows. But Buddhists, such as ***Dignaga*** and ***Dharmakirti***, deny that there are any objective generalities structuring and causally regulating reality that consists of instantaneous unique and indescribable particulars (***svalakshana***). If there are neither shared properties nor even resemblances, how do words and concepts operate?

The answer is that word-meanings and concepts 'exclude the other'. While there is no positive property shared by all individual cows, what all cows have in common is their being different from whatever is not a cow. We apply a meaning such as 'cow' just on the basis of the difference of cows from everything else. This 'difference from non-cows' is not a positive feature or a resemblance. It is at best a boundary. The word 'cow' does not stand for a property or essence. We sort some particulars when it suits human interests. Language is a network of mutually exclusive meanings that we have conventionally constructed in accordance with what matters for us. To illustrate: we apply the word 'analgesic' to a variety of pills with totally distinct pharmacological properties because